CHAPTER 6

Barefoot

The retreat began exactly as planned. Aparna found this reassuring. The transport had worked. The food had arrived. Twenty-two women had signed up, and by ten o'clock all twenty-two were standing inside a farmhouse two hours outside Delhi.

The evidence suggested a good beginning. The farmhouse offered something less measurable. Open fields surrounded the property. Trees interrupted sightlines. Stone pathways wandered wherever they pleased. Nothing appeared particularly interested in structure.

Good. That was the point.

The Udaan team had spent weeks preparing the weekend. Not to recreate another conference room outside the city, but to remove the familiar protections of one.

Inside the open-sided pavilion, twenty-two chairs stood in a wide circle. No tables. No projector. No stage. No carefully branded banners reminding anybody why they had come. Only the women and, beyond them, a large patch of grass.

Most had arrived carrying notebooks. Several appeared ready for instruction. One woman near the front seemed to be searching for a screen. Another kept glancing at the empty wall behind Aparna, as though something might yet be projected onto it.

The woman near the front frowned. "Excuse me."

Aparna smiled. "Yes?"

"Is this the workshop?"

The room laughed.

"That's what I'm trying to determine," another participant muttered, and the laughter came again, louder.

Aparna nodded. "It is."

The woman looked at the place where a screen should have been. “No projector?”

“No.”

“No presentation?”

“No.”

“Then what exactly are we doing?”

Aparna looked around the circle. Twenty-two women looked back at her, curious and suspicious and slightly concerned, a few with pens already uncapped.

“Let’s find out.”

The answer produced several exchanged glances. Good. Notebooks stayed shut on laps. Nobody looked particularly enlightened. The workshop hadn’t begun and the women already seemed unsure whether one existed.

Aparna placed her notebook beside her chair and began to take off her shoes, one at a time, with a deliberation that quieted the room. The women watched. She lined the shoes up beside her chair.

A woman laughed. “What are you doing?”

Aparna smiled. “I’ve spent enough of my life in conference rooms.”

More laughter.

After a brief hesitation she lowered herself into the chair and tucked her feet underneath her. Not at the front, not standing, not presenting. Inside.

“You’re serious?” someone asked.

“Unfortunately.”

The laughter spread more easily this time. Aparna looked around the group.

“For the next two days, nobody has to impress anybody.”

Silence. A few women exchanged glances. It sounded suspiciously simple.

“No networking.”

A woman frowned at once. “That’s disappointing.”

The room laughed.

“No elevator pitches.”

More laughter.

“No introductions that begin with your job title.”

One participant raised an eyebrow. “How will anyone know I’ve been successful?”

Aparna pointed at her. “We’ll take that risk.”

The room relaxed, just slightly. Aparna looked around the circle again: the grass, the trees, the women, the uncertainty.

“Let’s start somewhere else.” She waited for the shuffling to stop. “What does money mean in your house?”

Nobody answered. The neem trees moved overhead. Eventually a woman in her fifties spoke.

“Security.” It came out at once, with no hesitation.

“Security from what?” Aparna asked.

The woman turned her bangle once around her wrist. “Depending on somebody.”

Several heads nodded.

“Stress,” said another woman, and the room erupted. It was the fastest agreement of the morning.

A third participant tilted her head. “Freedom.”

“Arguments,” a fourth offered.

More laughter.

“That too,” Aparna said.

Shoulders came down from where they had been sitting. Then a voice from somewhere near the back, quiet and almost reluctant.

“Silence.”

The laughter stopped.

Aparna looked up. “What do you mean?”

The woman shrugged. “When there isn’t enough money, everybody talks about it. When there is enough money, nobody does.”

The room grew thoughtful. Somebody nodded, slowly.

Another participant raised her hand. “I don’t think money is actually my problem.”

Interesting. “What is?” Aparna asked.

The woman took longer to answer than anyone expected. “I think I’m waiting.”

The room shifted.

“Waiting for what?”

“I don’t know.” She laughed at herself. “That’s the frustrating part.”

A few people smiled.

“Permission,” said another participant.

Heads turned.

“What?”

“I’m waiting for permission.”

“From who?”

The woman stared at the grass beyond the pavilion. The answer took a while. “I honestly don’t know anymore.”

Silence. A second woman’s hand went up at once. “That one.”

The group laughed.

“That’s me,” she added, and another woman pointed at herself. “Me too.”

The room had become unexpectedly animated, voices overlapping. Aparna’s notebook still lay closed beside her shoes, its pages of careful handwriting suddenly beside the point.

A woman in her forties, in a yellow kurta, leaned forward. “I’ve wanted to start a business for six years.”

Several people looked over.

“What kind?”

“Catering.”

“Why haven’t you?”

The woman laughed. “I’ll tell you when I figure it out.”

More laughter.

“No, really.” She shrugged. “I keep taking courses.”

“How many?”

She counted on her fingers, lips moving. “Seven.”

The room exploded.

“Seven?”

“Seven.”

“Were they useful?”

“Very.”

“Then why haven’t you started?”

The woman smiled, a little sadly. “Because every course convinces me I need one more course.”

The circle went quiet. Aparna reached into the grass for her notebook and wrote the sentence down. Not for the workshop. For herself.

Another participant raised a hand. “I had the opposite problem.”

Everyone turned.

“What do you mean?”

“I knew absolutely nothing.” The room laughed. “So I started.”

“What?”

“Everything.”

The laughter grew louder.

“That sounds reckless.”

“It was.”

More laughter.

The woman shrugged. “But I learned something.”

“What?”

Her smile softened. “I trusted myself more after making mistakes than I did before trying to avoid them.”

Silence. Nobody reached for a phone. Nobody checked the time. Even the birds suddenly seemed excessively loud.

Aparna looked around the circle. Nobody seemed interested in moving on, not to the agenda, not to the schedule, not even to lunch.

Women kept talking long after the conversation should have ended. Small groups formed on their own, merged, and formed again.

One participant came over to Aparna while the others drifted towards the tea. “I wasn’t planning to come.”

Aparna smiled. “Why?”

“I’d nearly convinced myself I wasn’t the sort of person these events were for.”

“And?”

The woman laughed. “Turns out I am.” She looked out across the lawn, at the women talking, the groups forming, the conversations continuing. “I don’t know whether I learned much about investing today.”

Aparna raised an eyebrow. “Encouraging.”

“Sorry.”

She let a longer silence go by. “I think I trust myself a little more than I did this morning.”

And she walked away. Aparna stayed where she was in the circle, barefoot, watching the empty chair the woman had left behind.

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The bonfire happened because nobody wanted the day to end. That was the official explanation. The truth was simpler. Nobody wanted to leave the conversation.

The fire sat in the middle of the lawn, throwing sparks towards the neem trees. Blankets appeared. Tea appeared. Stories appeared. The same mysterious force seemed responsible for all three.

Aparna sat slightly outside the circle with her tea, not facilitating, listening.

For a while people talked about ordinary things. Children. Parents. Career changes. The absurdity of Delhi traffic. Safe subjects.

Somebody said, “If nobody could judge your decision…” She let it hang while a log shifted in the fire. “What would you do differently?”

The fire cracked. The conversation vanished. For several seconds nobody spoke.

“I would’ve left years ago,” a woman said.

Nobody asked what she meant. Nobody needed to.

“Same,” said a voice from across the circle.

“Definitely.”

Someone laughed softly. “Apparently we’ve all been living the same life.”

The laughter that followed sounded different. More honest.

“What stopped you?” someone asked.

The first woman stared into the fire. “I kept waiting until I felt ready.”

“Did it happen?”

“No.” She said it without hesitation.

“So what changed?”

The woman looked up. “I got tired of asking fear for permission.”

Nobody rushed to answer. The fire handled the silence.

“I actually left,” said another participant.

Heads turned. “And?”

“I spent two years wondering whether it was a mistake.”

The circle laughed.

“That’s not very inspiring.”

“No.” She smiled. “But it’s true. Eventually I worked something out.”

“What?”

She shrugged. “I assumed the uncertainty meant something had gone wrong.” Somebody pulled a blanket higher over her knees. “It hadn’t.”

A little later, another participant spoke, very quietly. “I think I’ve spent years asking permission from people who don’t even know they’re being asked.”

Nobody laughed. Nobody asked her to explain. Across the fire, one woman wiped her eyes with the back of her wrist. Another stared into her tea. A third simply nodded, slowly, again and again.

Aparna found she was no longer watching whoever spoke. She was watching the faces of the people listening. Nobody had stood up in hours. Nobody had asked her what came next. Somebody fed the fire, and somebody else refilled a cup that was not her own.

The next morning, before breakfast, Aparna came out to find several women already awake. Talking, making tea, continuing conversations that had begun the evening before. Nothing was scheduled. No session was running. No slide deck existed. The retreat was happening anyway.

Weeks later, while going through photographs, she stopped at one. A cluster of women sat barefoot on the grass, mid-laugh, mid-sentence, a hand frozen in the air. Nobody was looking at the camera. No agenda, no programme, no workshop in sight. At the edge of the frame lay a heap of shoes nobody had come back for.

She looked at it for a long moment.

What Was Being Built?

> *The retreat mattered. The conversations mattered. The workshop mattered. Something else had been growing inside all three. Aparna wasn't entirely sure what to call it.*

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